

Family Acrocephalidae

Reed warblers and allies

Length 5–9 in (12–21 cm)
Species 61

This group of Old World warblers includes species that are restricted to wet reeds or fen vegetation and others that also breed in riverside bushes and ditches. These habitats are often threatened, but also easily recreated, so some species are common, others endangered, others recovering with habitat restoration projects. There are two main groups: one small and sleek, the other larger, like “twice-size” reed warblers, often associated with taller and sturdier stands of reeds in warmer countries. All have similar lifestyles and general appearance and several groups of species can be difficult to separate. Most are plain brown above and paler below, with little distinct pattern, but others are more or less streaked above and striped on the head. They are adapted to sidling upward on vertical stems, tail down, head up, from which they sing. Occasionally one will fly low and fast across a gap in a reedbed, or move into nearby trees to forage for

CLAMOROUS REEDWARBLER
A marshland warbler found in northeast Africa and Asia, Acrocephalus stentoreus nests in reeds and other wetland plants, usually over the water. About 7–8 in (18–20 cm) long, it feeds on butterflies, dragonflies, flies, other insects, and small frogs. The female lays 3–6 dark-speckled white eggs. When singing, the male repeats phrases 3 or 4 times.

insects. Some have fluttering, undulating songflights. Their songs have a distinct rhythmic pattern of various guttural, squeaking or chattering notes, but the marsh warbler is a particularly expert mimic, incorporating songs and calls from birds in its African wintering grounds as well as European species in its song. Nests are built around upright stems, tightly woven or slung between “basket handles.” Some species are regularly parasitized by cuckoos. The majority are long-distance migrants, European species typically moving to Africa in autumn.



Family Alaudidae

Larks

Length 5–8 in (13–20 cm)
Species 97

Larks are found in virtually all parts of the world—North and South America, Africa, Europe, Asia, and Australia. The skylark, famous for its far-reaching song during flight, is the most well-known member of this family. Larks are ground-dwelling birds, mostly with streaked brown, cryptic plumage that provides good camouflage on the fields and deserts they inhabit; some species, however, have black and white markings. Males and females usually appear similar. Some species, such as the skylark and crested lark, have a crest of feathers that they raise in territorial and courtship displays and when singing. Larks usually have a strong and undulating flight, although they tend to flutter over short distances. The skylark’s

song-flight is a vertical ascent, high into the sky. Many other species have a climbing or circling song-flight. Larks feed on invertebrates, plant matter, and seeds. Many species flock in autumn and winter and only a few species migrate. The females lay 2–6 eggs, which are generally speckled, in nests made on the ground; the young chicks often leave the nest before they can fly.



Family Locustellidae

Grassbirds and allies

Length 6–8 in (12–20 cm)
Species 62

This Old World group includes birds that have a distinctive song pattern, based on a repetitive ticking, trilling,



COMMON GRASSHOPPER WARBLER
Increasingly scarce, Locustella naevia is found in Europe and western Asia and winters in Africa and India. It is 5 in (12.5 cm) long, and favors meadows, ditches, and marshland edges, creeping among weeds and grass, and climbing up stems. Its song is a very long-lasting, insectlike reeling, with only short pauses.

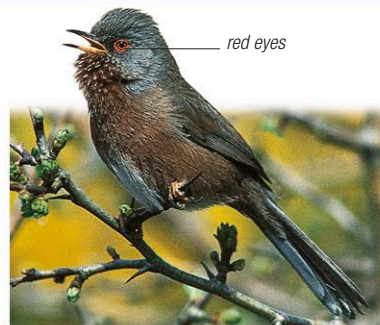
Family Sylviidae

Sylviid babblers

Length 11–17 cm (5–7 in)
Species 70

A varied group of Old World bush, heath, or woodland warblers, are rather robust and thick-billed compared with the leaf warblers. Some have dark caps or hoods, or contrasting whiter throats, or colored rings around the eyes; others are plainer; many have white tail sides. Their songs are varied, often unmusical, but some are excellent songsters. Most are long-distance migrants.

or buzzing note, creating insectlike or mechanical songs that distinguish the species. They prefer low growth, including thick bushes and scrub, taller grasses, a mix of grasses growing up through low bushes, or more pure stands of reed. Some are plain and brown, looking much like the reed warblers but with rounder wings and tails, while others are more or less streaked, often difficult to identify, and they are also extremely inconspicuous, crouching in dense cover, even if approached closely. All are long-distance migrants.

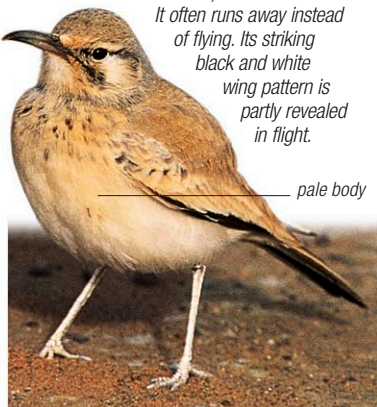


DARTFORD WARBLER
Found in western Europe and northwest Africa, Sylvia undata is one of the nonmigratory warblers in this region. Winter is a critical time for this species, particularly in the UK, which lies at the northern limit of its range. It is 5 in (13 cm) long, with a long tail, which is often cocked, and short wings.

EURASIAN SKYLARK
Alauda arvensis, 7–7½ in (18–19 cm) long, is a streaked, brown lark of farmland and open spaces known for its continuous song when in hovering flight. It is common in North Africa, Europe, and parts of Asia, and has been introduced in Australia and New Zealand. Northern populations migrate south in winter.



GREATER HOPOE-LARK
Measuring 7–8 in (18–20 cm) in length, Alaemon alaudipes inhabits desert and semidesert areas of North Africa (including the Sahara) and West Asia. It often runs away instead of flying. Its striking black and white wing pattern is partly revealed in flight.



HORNED LARK
Also known as the shore lark, Eremophila alpestris inhabits tundra and steppe in Europe, and prairie, farmland, and desert in North America. It is also found in North Africa and Asia. About 5½–6½ in (14–17 cm) long, it has little “horns” of feathers.

